

market had deemed him past his sell-by date. Ten years on, the realities of sport took over. He went unsold in the auction ahead of the ongoing 11th season and soon announced his retirement. His 'showman' title has passed on to another spunky, hotheaded superstar, Iranian allrounder Mohammad Mohammadreza Shadlou Chiyaneh.

"Look at the generations of players coming through. It's not only about player exposure and confidence; it's also about player height and weight. Now kabaddi has become about speed and agility instead of the earlier focus on brute strength," he explains.

#### Balancing faith with the market

Rao says the fact that defenders now fetch as much money as raiders — something he likens to how bowlers are now valued just as much as batters in the IPL — is also due to this shift. Earlier, raiding was considered the more glamorous skill. Today, a large chunk of players sees a higher value in being all-rounders. Pawan Sehrawat, the Indian captain and easily among the nation's smartest raiders, often doubles up in defence. This sets him apart and gives him an edge over an old-school muscle man-raider like Maninder Singh. Inamdar, Mohit Goyat. Even the league's latest raiding sensations, Devank (Patna Pirates) and Sushil Kambrekar (Bengal Warriorz), are handy in the backline.

Team dynamics have also evolved over the decade. Teams have had to balance faith in players and build personalities who can define their brand of kabaddi with actual performances on the mat. Warriorz have persisted with Maninder despite the ups and downs that come through in his season's raiding trajectory. Pune has built its brand around a core of five homegrown academy-developed youngsters who took the side to its maiden title in 2023.



Apurv Gupta, CEO of the Warriorz, calls it a chicken-and-egg situation.

"Maninder is Bengal Warriorz, and Bengal Warriorz is Maninder in some shape or form. That's the kind of association we want to build with a player," he explains. "We want to bring in players, have long-term associations with them, groom them, and build the brand around them." This, of course, has been a formula we've seen generate rich dividends in the IPL. The Pandya brothers and Ishan Kishan with Mumbai Indians, Yashasvi Jaiswal with Rajasthan Royals, and Chennai Super Kings sticking to tried and tested talents are just a few examples.

**Rising star:** Devank (centre) has made heads turn this season by topping the raiding charts ahead of established names like Pawan Sehrawat, Ashu Malik and Arjun Deshwal.

"A lot goes on behind the scenes. People see and evaluate a player based on just the 22 matches they play. But whether he was playing through pain, or whether his performance dipped for any other reason, these are all factors we consider. Good or bad seasons sometimes don't dictate the players we back," Gupta elaborates.

Kailash Kandpal, CEO of the Puneri Paltan, credits this frustration



« While more international fixtures would undoubtedly help elevate kabaddi's global stature, PKL serves as a critical platform for developing and nurturing talent that feeds into the national team — Anupam Goswami, Business Head, Mashal Sports & League Chairman, PKL »